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MASTER OF THE GAME

No world leader watched John Kennedy's handling of the Cuban invasion more carefully and was prepared to draw from it more far-reaching conclusions than the sixty-seven-year-old leader of the Soviet Union, Nikita Khrushchev.

Fat, bold, full of energy, prone to bravado, theatrics, and often bluff, Khrushchev cut a very different figure from that of the young American president. Born to poverty and low social status, he was also Kennedy's complete opposite in upbringing, career trajectory, and political ideology. If the young Kennedy's ambitions were driven by a desire to live up to the expectations of his strong-willed father, Khrushchev's were inspired by his mother's desire to see her son succeed in life, unlike her weak husband, considered to be the failure in the family. If Kennedy received the best education his country could provide, Khrushchev never graduated from college. If Kennedy's only experience of managing people was limited to his command of PT-109, the patrol torpedo boat during the war,